

Exercise:

Coaching Checklist for PMs

1. Coaching mindset

- ☐ Treat developing people as job #1
- ☐ Judge your success by the growth of your people
- ☐ Focus on empowerment, not task control
- ☐ Create ownership of outcomes, not dependency on you
- ☐ Remove impediments, clarify context, and coach judgment
- ☐ Watch for insecurity, ego, or need for recognition
- ☐ Encourage diverse viewpoints and constructive disagreement
- ☐ Build trust intentionally and continuously
- ☐ Praise publicly and criticize privately
- ☐ Address mistakes directly and promptly
- ☐ Ensure every person has an explicit coach

2. Skills assessment

- ☐ Assess each person's current capability vs. role expectations
- ☐ Rate both expectations and current capability by skill area
- ☐ Identify the biggest gaps
- ☐ Focus on the top 3 gaps first
- ☐ Reassess periodically
- ☐ Use assessment to guide development, not replace coaching

3. Product knowledge coaching

- ☐ Build user and customer knowledge
- ☐ Build data fluency
- ☐ Build industry and domain knowledge
- ☐ Build business and company knowledge
- ☐ Build product operational knowledge
- ☐ Expect the person to become deeply credible in the product

4. Process and execution coaching

- ☐ Teach discovery methods
- ☐ Teach optimization methods
- ☐ Teach delivery methods and tradeoffs
- ☐ Teach the product development process in your company
- ☐ Teach risk framing: value, usability, feasibility, viability
- ☐ Ensure they understand their role in discovery and delivery

5. People skills coaching

- ☐ Coach team collaboration
- ☐ Coach stakeholder collaboration
- ☐ Coach product evangelism and communication
- ☐ Coach leadership and influence
- ☐ Observe real interactions and coach from them
- ☐ Reinforce trust, respect, and mutual accountability

6. Coaching plan

- ☐ Create a written coaching plan for priority gaps
- ☐ Define learning actions: reading, coaching, training, exercises, exposure
- ☐ Give stretch opportunities matched to readiness
- ☐ Develop strengths, not only weaknesses
- ☐ Connect development to future growth and promotion
- ☐ Review progress weekly

7. Run strong 1:1s

- ☐ Hold 1:1s at least weekly
- ☐ Protect the meeting from casual cancellation
- ☐ Use it primarily for development, not status
- ☐ Listen more than you talk
- ☐ Build trust and candor
- ☐ Share context and expectations
- ☐ Discuss progress on learning and development
- ☐ Give specific, timely, constructive feedback
- ☐ Help the person think and act like a strong product leader
- ☐ Use the 1:1 to connect dots across teams and issues

8. Use stronger coaching tools

- ☐ Use written narratives for major decisions
 - ☐ Require clear thinking before presentations
 - ☐ Use writing to expose weak logic and missing evidence
 - ☐ Review the narrative and FAQ together
 - ☐ Coach for clarity, logic, and persuasiveness
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Strategic context

9. Teach strategic context explicitly

- ☐ Make strategic context part of onboarding
- ☐ Ensure every PM understands the broader business context
- ☐ Revisit context regularly, not only once
- ☐ Verify the person can explain how their team contributes to company goals

10. Ensure understanding of the six strategic context elements

- ☐ Company mission
- ☐ Company scorecard/health metrics / KPIs
- ☐ Company objectives
- ☐ Product vision
- ☐ Product principles
- ☐ Team topology
- ☐ Product strategy

11. Company mission

- ☐ Ensure the person knows why the company exists
- ☐ Ensure they can connect their work to the mission
- ☐ Check whether they use the mission in judgment and prioritization

12. Company scorecard

- ☐ Teach the key business health metrics
- ☐ Ensure they understand what healthy vs. unhealthy looks like
- ☐ Ensure they understand key funnels and business dynamics
- ☐ Confirm they know which metrics matter most

13. Company objectives

- ☐ Teach the current company objectives
- ☐ Emphasize that objectives are outcomes, not outputs
- ☐ Connect key results back to the company scorecard
- ☐ Ensure the person can explain how the team objectives ladder up

14. Product vision and principles

- ☐ Ensure the PM understands the future the company is trying to create
- ☐ Ensure they understand why that future matters to customers
- ☐ Teach the product principles that guide tradeoffs
- ☐ Check whether they actually use those principles in decisions

15. Team topology and product strategy

- ☐ Ensure the PM understands what each team is responsible for
 - ☐ Clarify where their team sits in the bigger picture
 - ☐ Teach the product strategy that connects company goals to team objectives
 - ☐ Check that the PM can explain why their objectives matter
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Ownership mindset

16. Coach's sense of ownership

- ☐ Coach thinking like an owner, not an employee
- ☐ Emphasize responsibility for outcomes, not just activity
- ☐ Reinforce that customers care about results, not effort
- ☐ Teach the PM to own obstacles, not just report them
- ☐ Expect them to bring context, not wait to be told what to do
- ☐ Reinforce taking responsibility when things go wrong
- ☐ Reinforce giving credit when things go well

17. Coach outcome orientation

- ☐ Ask whether the PM is solving for output or outcome
- ☐ Evaluate performance by business and customer results
- ☐ Reinforce that ownership includes cross-functional relationships

- ☐ Coach the PM to act with long-term company value in mind
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Managing time

18. Protect time for real product work

- ☐ Ensure the PM has substantial time for discovery and problem-solving
- ☐ Help them identify where their time is currently going
- ☐ Distinguish product management work from project management work
- ☐ Block recurring time for deep product work
- ☐ Protect that time from routine meeting sprawl
- ☐ Reduce unnecessary coordination work where possible
- ☐ Consider delivery/project support if PM time is being consumed
- ☐ Coach the PM to spend time ensuring what gets built is worth building

19. Diagnose time misuse

- Check whether the PM is overspending time on project tracking
 - Check whether they are choosing tangible admin work over ambiguous product work
 - Check whether the calendar makes quality thinking impossible
 - Address time management as an explicit coaching topic
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Thinking and judgment

20. Coach thinking, not just knowledge

- ☐ Distinguish intelligence from actual thinking
- ☐ Distinguish acquiring knowledge from applying knowledge
- ☐ Expect the PM to think through problems before escalating
- ☐ Teach structured problem solving
- ☐ Check how the PM responds when they do not know the answer
- ☐ Coach them to reason through value, usability, feasibility, and viability together
- ☐ Use writing and discussion to build critical thinking
- ☐ Reinforce that product work is fundamentally problem-solving

Team collaboration

21. Coach true collaboration

- ☐ Define collaboration as solving problems together
- ☐ Clarify that collaboration is not consensus for its own sake
- ☐ Clarify that collaboration is not artifact production
- ☐ Clarify that collaboration is not a compromise that produces mediocre outcomes
- ☐ Reinforce that collaboration aims at solutions that are valuable, usable, feasible, and viable

22. Strengthen cross-functional collaboration

- ☐ Build true collaboration between PM, design, and engineering
- ☐ Encourage teams to work around prototypes and shared problem exploration
- ☐ Ensure each discipline brings its expertise rather than deferring blindly
- ☐ Reinforce that no one should try to do the other person's job
- ☐ Expect each person to come prepared, having done the homework
- ☐ Watch for arrogance or premature certainty from the PM
- ☐ Watch for the PM reverting to requirement handoff behavior
- ☐ Coach collaboration with customers and prospects when appropriate

23. Diagnose collaboration failures

- ☐ Check whether the PM has done the business and customer homework
 - ☐ Check whether arrogance is suppressing team contribution
 - ☐ Check whether artifacts are replacing collaborative work
 - ☐ Check whether the team is discussing solutions together early enough
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Stakeholder collaboration

24. Reframe stakeholder relationships

- ☐ Teach that stakeholders are partners, not obstacles
- ☐ Teach that the PM is not there merely to gather requirements

- ☐ Teach that the PM is not there to dictate solutions to stakeholders
- ☐ Ensure the PM understands each stakeholder's role and constraints
- ☐ Teach how stakeholder input contributes to business viability

25. Build trust with stakeholders

- ☐ Identify the critical stakeholder relationships for each PM
- ☐ Encourage relationship-building before moments of conflict
- ☐ Encourage regular 1:1 relationship time with key stakeholders
- ☐ Build rapport, not just transactional contact
- ☐ Help the PM learn how to navigate different personalities
- ☐ Reinforce that mutual trust makes disagreement productive

26. Coach executive collaboration

- ☐ Ensure the PM has done enough homework to talk credibly with executives
 - ☐ Coach careful listening to executive concerns and constraints
 - ☐ Teach the PM to bring solutions, not just problems
 - ☐ Prepare the PM for increasingly broad executive expectations
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Imposter syndrome and preparedness

27. Coach preparedness, not performative confidence

- ☐ Normalize doubt as a signal to prepare better
 - ☐ Teach the PM to use anxiety as a trigger for homework and rehearsal
 - ☐ Require preparation for important presentations and reviews
 - ☐ Insist on draft reviews and honest feedback before high-stakes meetings
 - ☐ Provide progressive exposure for nervous presenters
 - ☐ Encourage training and rehearsal where needed
 - ☐ Reinforce that executive trust drops when a PM appears unprepared
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Customer-centricity

28. Define customer-centricity clearly

- ☐ Protect the meaning of “customer.”
- ☐ Distinguish real customers from stakeholders and internal partners
- ☐ Reinforce that the role is to innovate on behalf of customers
- ☐ Teach that product changes, outages, and support moments reveal true customer care

29. Build customer contact into the role

- ☐ Expect regular direct customer interaction
- ☐ Encourage at least several meaningful customer conversations each week
- ☐ Review what the PM learned from those conversations
- ☐ Ask for stories, not just summaries
- ☐ Encourage the PM to share customer insights across the company
- ☐ Build their reputation as someone who deeply knows customers

30. Coach customer judgment

- ☐ Watch for contempt or dismissiveness toward customers
 - ☐ Watch for the PM assuming customers are not smart
 - ☐ Teach empathy and respect
 - ☐ Teach urgency and calm during customer pain moments
 - ☐ Reinforce that customer-centricity is shown in hard tradeoff situations
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Integrity

31. Coach integrity as a practical operating standard

- ☐ Treat integrity as foundational to trust
- ☐ Discuss pressures that challenge integrity in day-to-day work
- ☐ Coach for difficult real-world situations, not abstract values only

32. Dependability

- ☐ Teach that commitments must be taken seriously
- ☐ Ensure commitments are based on informed judgment
- ☐ Ensure the PM does not overcommit before sufficient discovery
- ☐ Ensure the PM relies on design and engineering expertise before committing
- ☐ Reinforce that what ships must actually solve the problem

- ☐ Coach the PM to build a reputation for dependable commitments

33. Company's best interests

- ☐ Teach the PM to act in the best interests of the company
- ☐ Watch for local optimization for only their team
- ☐ Encourage helping other teams when it benefits the company
- ☐ Recognize visible acts of company-first behavior
- ☐ Coach's decisions that may not maximize convenience for the team but are better for the business

34. Accountability

- ☐ Teach willingness to take responsibility for mistakes
 - ☐ Ask what the PM could have done better, even when others contributed
 - ☐ Reinforce that accountability is not blame-seeking
 - ☐ Reinforce that accountability means learning, adjusting, and improving
 - ☐ Ensure the PM does not hide behind cross-functional complexity
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Decision making

35. Build a strong foundation for decisions

- ☐ Reinforce that good decisions rest on integrity
- ☐ Reinforce that decisions must aim at customer and business outcomes
- ☐ Help the PM bring leaders and stakeholders along through rationale and respect
- ☐ Coach for decisions others can understand, even when they disagree

36. Right-size decision analysis

- ☐ Teach the PM to judge the level of risk
- ☐ Teach the PM to judge the consequences if wrong
- ☐ Match the depth of analysis to the importance of the decision
- ☐ Identify what information is critical before deciding
- ☐ Avoid over-analyzing low-consequence decisions
- ☐ Avoid under-analyzing high-consequence decisions
- ☐ Consider revenue, legal, stakeholder, and customer implications

- ☐ Encourage a clear plan of attack for consequential choices

37. Collaboration-based decision making

- ☐ Clarify that decision-making is not consensus, voting, or benevolent dictatorship
- ☐ Teach when to defer to the tech lead on enabling technology
- ☐ Teach when to defer to product design on customer experience
- ☐ Teach when the PM must work with stakeholders on business viability
- ☐ Reinforce that the hardest choices often concern value tradeoffs

38. Resolving disagreements

- ☐ Normalize healthy disagreement
- ☐ Teach when to run a test instead of arguing
- ☐ Coach selection of the least expensive useful test
- ☐ Use prototypes and evidence to resolve uncertainty
- ☐ Escalate only when necessary after collaborative attempts

39. Transparency

- ☐ Require a clear rationale for important decisions
- ☐ Use notes for smaller decisions
- ☐ Use written narratives and FAQs for major decisions
- ☐ Anticipate objections and address them explicitly
- ☐ Make reasoning visible to leaders and stakeholders

40. Disagree and commit

- ☐ Teach the team to debate honestly
- ☐ Teach them to accept a final decision once made
- ☐ Prevent undermining decisions after the fact
- ☐ Ensure the PM can explain the rationale even when it was not their preferred option
- ☐ Expect the PM to help make the final decision successful

Warning signs and anti-patterns

41. Coaching anti-patterns

- ☐ Coaching is treated as secondary work
- ☐ 1:1s become status meetings
- ☐ The manager talks more than listens
- ☐ Feedback is delayed until reviews
- ☐ Manager micromanages
- ☐ Manager avoids difficult conversations
- ☐ Weak performance is tolerated for too long

42. PM anti-patterns

- ☐ PM focuses on activity over outcomes
 - ☐ PM acts like a project coordinator rather than a product leader
 - ☐ PM lacks strategic context
 - ☐ PM has weak customer contact
 - ☐ PM has not done the homework
 - ☐ PM dominates rather than collaborates
 - ☐ PM avoids ownership
 - ☐ PM overcommits
 - ☐ PM appears unprepared in important forums
 - ☐ PM makes opaque decisions
 - ☐ PM resists disagreement but fails to commit
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Manager self-audit

43. Weekly manager check

- ☐ Did I spend real time coaching this week?
- ☐ Do my people know I care about their development?
- ☐ Have I clarified the strategic context recently?
- ☐ Do I know each person's top development gaps?
- ☐ Did I observe and coach real behavior this week?
- ☐ Did I give honest, useful feedback this week?
- ☐ Am I fostering ownership rather than dependence?
- ☐ Am I protecting time for real product work?
- ☐ Am I coaching thinking and judgment, not only execution?
- ☐ Am I helping PMs become more customer-centric?
- ☐ Am I coaching collaboration across teams and stakeholders?

- ☐ Am I reinforcing integrity and accountability?
- ☐ Am I helping my team make better decisions?

44. Run effective meetings

- ☐ Challenge whether a meeting is needed at all
- ☐ Prefer asynchronous communication when it can serve the purpose
- ☐ Remember, meetings are expensive because they are synchronous
- ☐ Be aware that meetings shape how executives judge your team, especially the PM
- ☐ Avoid poorly prepared, slow, low-value meetings

45. Be clear on the type of meeting

- ☐ Identify whether the meeting is for communication, decision-making, or problem-solving
- ☐ Do not mix purposes carelessly
- ☐ For communication meetings, verify that the content is too important or complex for async
- ☐ For decision meetings, verify that a real decision is needed beyond what the team can decide alone
- ☐ For problem-solving meetings, verify that the issue is genuinely hard enough to benefit from real-time group thinking

46. Organize meetings well

- ☐ State the purpose clearly
- ☐ Decide who is essential vs. optional
- ☐ Keep the attendee list tight
- ☐ Postpone if essential people cannot attend
- ☐ Prepare thoroughly before the meeting starts
- ☐ Ensure the right content, medium, visuals, and data are ready
- ☐ For decision meetings, prepare the written narrative
- ☐ For problem-solving meetings, prepare context, framing, and relevant facts
- ☐ Anticipate likely questions in advance

47. Facilitate meetings well

- ☐ Facilitate the needed decision or solution
 - ☐ Do not let the meeting drift aimlessly
 - ☐ Do not confuse facilitation with policing
 - ☐ Keep discussion tied to purpose
 - ☐ Make sure the room understands the decision, even if people disagree
 - ☐ Close the loop with explicit follow-up and next steps
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Ethics

48. Add ethics explicitly to product coaching

- ☐ Teach the classic four product risks: value, usability, feasibility, viability
- ☐ Add a fifth explicit question: Should we build it?
- ☐ Treat ethics as a first-class consideration, not something buried inside viability
- ☐ Make room for uncomfortable questions about consequences
- ☐ Reinforce that product teams have special responsibility because they create and ship new things

49. Teach ethical product judgment

- ☐ Ask how the solution affects customers beyond revenue
- ☐ Ask how the solution affects the broader stakeholder community
- ☐ Ask about environmental, social, regulatory, and reputational consequences
- ☐ Ask whether you would be proud to have the work publicly scrutinized
- ☐ Ask whether the product choice could embarrass the company if exposed
- ☐ Reinforce that good intentions can still create harmful unintended consequences

50. Coach how to raise ethical concerns

- ☐ Encourage people to raise concerns thoughtfully
- ☐ Coach them to avoid moral grandstanding or accusatory framing
- ☐ Frame concerns in terms of protecting the company's best interests
- ☐ Ensure they understand enough of the business context to speak credibly
- ☐ Help them involve their manager when the situation is sensitive
- ☐ Create an environment where uncomfortable questions are acceptable

51. Watch for company-level ethics signals

- ☐ Check whether ethics is regularly discussed in product work
 - ☐ Check whether anybody is clearly responsible for ethical oversight
 - ☐ Watch whether leadership seems genuinely concerned with integrity and ethics
 - ☐ Take seriously the signs that the company consistently ignores ethical implications
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Happiness and sustainability

52. Treat team happiness as a management responsibility

- ☐ Accept that managers strongly influence whether product people are fulfilled or miserable
- ☐ Check regularly whether each person feels their work is meaningful
- ☐ Check whether they are progressing in their career and capability
- ☐ Check whether they are building the relationships needed to succeed
- ☐ Learn what is personally meaningful to each person

53. Reinforce meaningful work

- ☐ Help people understand why their work matters
- ☐ Connect team contributions to company and customer impact
- ☐ Reinforce meaning both privately and publicly
- ☐ Do not assume people automatically see the significance of their work

54. Build personal relationships

- ☐ Build trust through a real personal connection
- ☐ Learn aspirations, motivations, and interests outside work
- ☐ Let people know you are committed to helping them succeed professionally and personally
- ☐ Create the kind of relationship that can sustain honest feedback
- ☐ Aim to become a trusted and valued part of their career story

55. Recognize people personally

- ☐ Assume most people want to feel valued
- ☐ Personalize recognition to the individual
- ☐ Use frequent, human recognition beyond compensation and promotion

- ☐ Notice whether someone dislikes public recognition but still values appreciation
- ☐ Recognize effort, growth, and contribution in ways that feel genuine

56. Coach healthy work habits

- ☐ Distinguish between an occasional healthy push and chronic overwork
- ☐ Watch for signs of burnout
- ☐ Talk explicitly about sustainability and the long game
- ☐ Reinforce that creative problem-solving requires recovery time
- ☐ Make sure intense pushes do not become the normal operating mode
- ☐ Coach people who cannot disengage from meaningful work

57. Model healthy behavior

- ☐ Remember, your actions speak louder than your words
- ☐ Avoid creating pressure through your own unhealthy patterns
- ☐ Be thoughtful about when you send messages and emails
- ☐ Share how you recharge and manage your time
- ☐ Model sustainable intensity rather than performative overwork

58. Support career planning honestly

- ☐ Help people think clearly about their career path
- ☐ Acknowledge when someone may need a different role or career
- ☐ Recognize the outsized influence managers have on employees' lives
- ☐ Support long-term flourishing, not only near-term team needs

Additional manager self-audit items

59. Meetings

- ☐ Did I cancel or convert low-value meetings when async would work?
- ☐ Did the meetings I ran have a clear purpose, preparation, and follow-up?
- ☐ Did I use written narratives for important decisions?

60. Ethics

- ☐ Did I explicitly ask whether we should build this, not only whether we can?

- ☐ Did I make space for ethical concerns without punishing people for raising them?
- ☐ Did I help my team think through unintended consequences?

61. Happiness

- ☐ Do I know what makes each person feel fulfilled?
- ☐ Am I reinforcing meaningful work frequently enough?
- ☐ Am I modeling healthy habits?
- ☐ Am I noticing burnout early?
- ☐ Am I helping people build careers, not just complete tasks?